ENERGY

Houthis deploy missiles and drones to attack ships in southern Red Sea, naval group says

PUBLISHED WED, JUL 22 2026•9:33 AM EDT UPDATED WED, JUL 22 2026•2:45 PM EDT



Spencer Kimball
@SPENCEKIMBALL

Listen 3min 15 15 1x

00:00 03:09

KEY POINTS

Houthi militants are ready to attack ships in the southern Red Sea, the Joint Maritime Information Center warned in a notice.

The militants have deployed missiles and drones near the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, the center said, citing sources close to the group.

The Houthis declared a maritime embargo of Saudi Arabia this week. Several tankers with Saudi cargo turned around before reaching Bab el-Mandeb.



VIDEO 02:55

Oil jumps amid Hormuz traffic drop, Red Sea threats

Iran's Houthi allies in Yemen have completed preparations to attack ships transiting the Red Sea's southern access point, a maritime security group led by the U.S. Navy has warned.

"Sources close to the group stated that the Houthis have completed preparations to attack shipping, including the deployment of missiles and drones positioned near Bab el-Mandeb," the Joint Maritime Information Center, or JMIC, told mariners in a notice Tuesday. The center, headquartered in Bahrain, provides security updates to commercial ships in the Middle East.

The European Union's naval mission in the Middle East warned Wednesday that "merchant vessels linked to Israeli, U.S. or Saudi interests" should "avoid transiting the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden until the threat level decreases."

The Houthis have repeatedly threatened to close the Bab el-Mandeb Strait during the U.S.-Iran war. The strait connects the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden, the Arabian Sea and global markets.

The militants declared a maritime embargo against Saudi Arabia on Monday, threatening to cut off the kingdom's oil exports through the Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb. Those exports have acted as a crucial relief valve for global oil markets as Iran attacks tankers in the Strait of Hormuz.

Riyadh has diverted millions of barrels per day of oil through a pipeline to the Yanbu terminal on the Red Sea. Exports from that terminal through the Bab el-Mandeb surged to 3.5 million barrels per day in June compared with just 240,000 bpd in the same period last year, according to Kpler data.

Commercial traffic has continued through the southern Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb with no attacks in the past two days, the JMIC said Tuesday. The threat to ships in the area remains "moderate," it said.

"No changes to commercial routing or transit patterns occurred, and vessels continued to use established lanes without disruption," the JMIC said.

Ship tracking firm Kpler, however, observed a 34% decline in traffic through the Bab el-Mandeb on Tuesday compared with Monday, when the Houthis declared the embargo against the Saudis.

Four tankers with Saudi cargo turned around before reaching Bab el-Mandeb on Tuesday, according to the maritime intelligence firm Windward. The ships are carrying 3.8 million barrels of crude oil, gasoil and naphtha, the firm said.

Iran, meanwhile, has stepped up its attacks on tankers in Hormuz as it tries to force vessels to transit the strait through its territorial waters. Three crude oil, products and chemical tankers have come under attack off the coast of Oman and the United Arab Emirates this week.

A dozen ships have been attacked in and around Hormuz since July 6, resulting in the deaths of two seafarers and more than a dozen injuries, according to the International Maritime Organization, a United Nations agency.

Choose CNBC as your preferred source on Google and never miss a moment from the most trusted name in business news.

TRENDING NOW



Fed Chair Warsh says central bank to reduce the number of rate-setting meetings in

MARKETS VIDEO WATCHLIST MENU



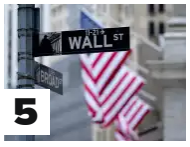
Fed holds rates steady despite concerns over inflation



Oracle stock pops 13% as long-term revenue forecast and clarity on financing ease debt concerns



Peltola campaign aides, DSCC officials helped recruit second Dan Sullivan in Alaska race: NYT



CLUB We're adding a new, high-profile AI play to our Bullpen stocks to watch list

Sponsored Links

FROM THE WEB

Doctors: This 1 Boxed Cereal Is On Their Radar For Forgetfulness

Memory Health Journal

Doctors Say Forgetfulness Begins When Seniors Can't Pronounce These 3 Phrases. Can You?

Hello Wellness 101

Select Personal Finance
Closed Captioning
News Releases
Corrections
Site Map
Careers
Contact

Join the CNBC Panel
Digital Products
Internships
About CNBC
Podcasts
Help

News Tips

Got a confidential news tip? We want to hear from you.

GET IN TOUCH

Advertise With Us

PLEASE CONTACT US

CNBC Newsletters

Sign up for free newsletters and get more CNBC delivered to your inbox

SIGN UP NOW

Get this delivered to your inbox, and more info about our products and services.

Ad Choices
Privacy Policy
Your Privacy Choices
CA Notice
Terms of Service

© 2026 Versant Media, LLC. All Rights Reserved. A Versant Media Company.

Data is a real-time snapshot *Data is delayed at least 15 minutes. Global Business and Financial News, Stock Quotes, and Market Data and Analysis.

Market Data Terms of Use and Disclaimers